

Before the Test

Before the Test

A Teen's Journal for School & Study Anxiety

NORTH STAR JOURNALS

Copyright © 2026 North Star Journals. All rights reserved.

No part of this journal may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without the prior written permission of the publisher, except for brief quotations embodied in critical reviews and certain other noncommercial uses permitted by copyright law.

This journal is intended for self-reflection and general well-being. It is not a substitute for professional mental-health care. If you are struggling, please reach out to a trusted adult, counselor, or crisis line. In the U.S., call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline). Outside the U.S., see findahelpline.com.

First edition, 2026.

Published by North Star Journals.

For anyone who has ever cried over a study guide.

HOW TO USE THIS JOURNAL

This is your journal. Use it in whatever order helps. Skip pages. Come back to pages. Nothing here is a test.

There are five sections. Grounding tools you can use in the moment. Prompts to help you get thoughts out of your head and onto paper. Trackers to spot patterns. A toolkit of small practices. And eight weeks of short reflections.

Try one prompt when your mind is loud. Try one tracker for a week. If a page feels wrong for you today, turn to another one. Progress is not linear, and neither is this book.

There are no wrong answers here. Write in pencil, pen, whatever. Scribble. Draw. Leave pages blank. This journal will not grade you.

If your anxiety is getting in the way of your daily life, please also talk to a trusted adult or a mental-health professional. Resources are on the last page.

CONTENTS

One · Start Here — five grounding tools

Two · Prompts — thirty pages to write it out

Three · Trackers — spot the patterns

Four · Your Toolkit — small practices for hard days

Five · Weekly Reflections — eight weeks

When you need more help · page 103

SECTION ONE

Start Here

Five grounding tools you can use anywhere.

5-4-3-2-1

Look around. Name five things you can see. Four things you can touch. Three things you can hear. Two things you can smell. One thing you can taste. Go slow. Your senses pull you back into your body.

NOTES

BOX BREATHING

Breathe in for four counts. Hold for four. Breathe out for four. Hold for four. Repeat four times. Draw a square in the air with your finger as you breathe, one side per count.

NOTES

BODY SCAN

Start at the top of your head. Slowly move your attention down: forehead, jaw, shoulders, chest, belly, arms, hands, legs, feet. Notice what's tight. Let it soften if it wants to. If it doesn't, that's fine.

NOTES

COLD WATER RESET

Splash cold water on your face, or hold an ice cube for a few seconds, or run your wrists under cold water for thirty seconds. The temperature shift interrupts the anxiety loop and signals your nervous system to slow down.

NOTES

NAME IT TO TAME IT

Say out loud, or write down, exactly what you're feeling. “I feel anxious because...” Being specific about the emotion — not just ‘bad’ — shrinks it a little. Try to name three feelings if you can.

NOTES

SECTION TWO

Prompts

*For the hour before, the night before, and every
ordinary school day.*

What test or assignment is on your mind right now? Write it out in one sentence.

What are you actually afraid will happen if this doesn't go well?

Whose voice is in your head about grades — a parent, a teacher, yourself? What are they saying?

Write down every step you'd need to feel prepared. Circle the next one.

What is one thing you know really well already? Remind yourself.

What subject makes your chest tight? What is one small thing that helps?

What does 'doing your best' actually mean, in your own words?

What would you tell a classmate who felt the way you feel about this test?

What is the story you tell yourself about being 'smart'? Is it fully true?

Write about a time you were scared you'd fail and didn't. How did you get through it?

What is one thing outside of school that you're good at? How did you get good at it?

What do you need before a test to feel steady? Food? Sleep? Quiet? Music?

What is your morning-of routine on a test day? What would you want it to be?

What are you comparing yourself to? Is that comparison fair to you?

What subject do you actually enjoy? What does your body feel like in that class?

What grade would be 'enough' for you on this? Not perfect — enough.

What is one hard question you don't understand yet? Who could you ask?

What would this test feel like if you weren't afraid of it? Describe it.

What are three things you did this week that were harder than this test?

What does your teacher not know about how much effort this has taken?

What is one small kindness you can do for yourself the night before?

What would 'over-preparing' look like? What would 'good-enough preparing' look like?

What are you afraid people will think of you? What would you think of them?

Write down what your anxiety is predicting will happen. Rate it 1-10 for likely.

What would you do this week if grades didn't exist for a moment?

What is one thing you understand now that you didn't a month ago?

What is a lie your anxiety tells you before a test? Write the truth next to it.

What are you going to do the moment the test is over, no matter how it went?

Finish this: 'Even if this doesn't go well, I still...'

Write yourself a permission slip: 'I am allowed to...' during this test week.

SECTION THREE

Trackers

Notice the patterns in your test and school stress.

ANXIETY LEVEL THIS WEEK

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT TRIGGERED IT	WHAT HELPED
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SLEEP TRACKER

DAY	HOURS	HOW I SLEPT	HOW I FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

MOOD CHECK-IN

DAY	MORNING	AFTERNOON	NIGHT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TEST AND SCHOOL STRESS LOG

DAY	WHERE / WHEN	BODY FEELING	WHAT I DID NEXT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ENERGY THIS WEEK

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT DRAINED ME	WHAT REFILLED ME
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ONE SMALL WIN

DAY	WIN OF THE DAY	WHO SAW IT	HOW IT FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

KINDNESS TO SELF

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ANXIETY LEVEL THIS WEEK

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT TRIGGERED IT	WHAT HELPED
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SLEEP TRACKER

DAY	HOURS	HOW I SLEPT	HOW I FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

MOOD CHECK-IN

DAY	MORNING	AFTERNOON	NIGHT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

TEST AND SCHOOL STRESS LOG

DAY	WHERE / WHEN	BODY FEELING	WHAT I DID NEXT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ENERGY THIS WEEK

DAY	LEVEL 1-10	WHAT DRAINED ME	WHAT REFILLED ME
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

ONE SMALL WIN

DAY	WIN OF THE DAY	WHO SAW IT	HOW IT FELT
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

KINDNESS TO SELF

DAY	WHAT I DID	HOW IT FELT	DO AGAIN?
Mon			
Tue			
Wed			
Thu			
Fri			
Sat			
Sun			

SECTION FOUR

Your Toolkit

Small practices you can return to on hard days.

STUDY BLOCK PLAN

Break the material into small chunks. Write each chunk on a line, with the smallest possible task next to it. One chunk = one line.

THE NIGHT-BEFORE WIND-DOWN

List three things to do the night before that are NOT studying: shower, snack, playlist, whatever calms you. Commit to them.

REHEARSE THE ROOM

Close your eyes. Picture walking in, sitting down, taking a breath, and starting. Write what you see. Rehearsing calm counts as studying.

THE 'IF I BLANK' PLAN

Write down what you'll do if your mind goes blank mid-test: breathe, skip and come back, re-read the question, next question. Have a plan.

FEAR VS. FACT

On the left, write what your anxiety predicts. On the right, write what is actually true about this test. Compare them.

EFFORT INVENTORY

Write down every hour you've already put into this material. Notice how much you've already done.

THE 5-MINUTE RESET

Halfway through a study session, set a 5-minute timer. Stand up. Water. Stretch. Look out a window. Then come back.

REFRAME 'I DON'T GET IT'

Change every 'I don't get it' to 'I don't get it YET.' Write down what specifically you don't get. That's your next study step.

ASK-FOR-HELP LIST

Write three questions you could bring to a teacher, tutor, or classmate. Pick one to actually send this week.

THE AFTER-TEST KINDNESS

Plan one small good thing for right after the test — no matter how it went. Snack, walk, playlist, nap. Commit to it now.

AFFIRMATIONS

Write down phrases that feel true (or that you want to be true). Circle the ones that help most. Come back to them.

- My grade is not my worth.
- I have prepared. I can trust that.
- One question at a time.
- It is okay to not know something yet.
- I am allowed to ask for help.
- Breathing is a study skill.
- Doing my best is not the same as being perfect.
- This test does not define me.

NOTES

SECTION FIVE

Weekly Reflections

Eight weeks of looking back and forward.

WEEK 1 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 1 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 2 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 2 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 3 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 3 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 4 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 4 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 5 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 5 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 6 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 6 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 7 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 7 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WEEK 8 · LOOKING BACK

What did you notice about your anxiety this week? What set it off? What helped, even a little?

WEEK 8 · LOOKING FORWARD

Pick one small thing to try next week. One breath, one message, one conversation. Small counts.

WHEN YOU NEED MORE HELP

This journal is for reflection, not treatment. If your anxiety is getting in the way of school, sleep, eating, friendships, or feeling safe, please talk to a trusted adult, a school counselor, or a therapist.

If you are in crisis:

- U.S. — Call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline).
- U.S. — Text HOME to 741741 (Crisis Text Line).
- U.K. — Call 116 123 (Samaritans).
- Global — findahelpline.com lists lines in your country.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call your local emergency number.

NOTES

NOTES

NOTES

NOTES